



△ Choosing a label

Romantic and sexual preferences can change over time. Some people discover the label that was once right for them needs to be reevaluated.

Discovering an identity

It can take time for teens to discover their sexual identity. For some, it's easy to find a term that perfectly suits their romantic and sexual attractions. Others might prefer to wait or to experiment first. Most people are teens when they develop an understanding of their romantic and sexual feelings, but some know from the time they are children, and others, not until they are adults.

PARENT TIPS

Be supportive

Parents commonly assume that their child's interests or values as a teenager are "just a phase." However, it can be damaging to treat an experience as if it is insignificant. Some teens will feel rejected and react defensively. Take your teen seriously, ask questions if they want to talk, and listen carefully to them. Find out about different sexual identities, and be prepared to challenge your own expectations and stereotypes.



◀ Safe space

Get to know the person your teen is dating by including them in family dinners and other events.

Heterosexism

Heterosexism is the common assumption that someone's sexual identity is straight. For LGBTQ+ individuals it can be exhausting to correct the same assumptions repeatedly.



△ Nosy relatives

When a relative asks a teenage boy if he has a girlfriend yet, they are assuming that he wants a girlfriend.

△ Difficult doctors

When a doctor presses a sexually active teenage girl to use contraception to avoid pregnancy, the doctor is assuming she is sexually active with a person who could get her pregnant.

ALERT!

Homophobia

Homophobia literally means the fear of people who are gay. People with homophobic views believe that being gay is morally and/or ethically wrong. They may deliberately ignore people who are gay, or be actively cruel toward them, through bullying, discrimination, or showing disrespect. Societies across the world are gradually becoming more accepting of people of different sexual identities.